

Vulpa

Now with italics!

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Fox is a common name for many species of omnivorous mammals belonging to the Canidae family. Foxes are small to medium-sized canids (slightly smaller than the medium-sized domestic dog), characterized by possessing a long narrow snout, and a bushy tail (or brush).

Members of about 37 species are referred to as foxes, of which only 12 species actually belong to the Vulpes genus of "true foxes." By far the most common and widespread species of fox is the red fox (Vulpes vulpes), although various species are found on almost every continent. The presence of fox-like carnivores all over the globe, together with their widespread reputation for cunning, has contributed to their appearance in popular culture and folklore in many societies around the world: (see also Foxes in culture).

The Modern English word "fox" is Old English, and comes from the Proto-Germanic word *fukh* – compare German *Fuchs*, Gothic *fauho*, Old Norse *foa* and Dutch *vos*. It corresponds to the Proto-Indo-European word *puk* – meaning "tail of it" (compare Sanskrit *puccha*, also "tail"). The bushy tail is also the source of the word for fox in Welsh: *llwynog*, from *llwyn*, "bush, grove". Lithuanian: *uodegis*, from *uodega*, "tail", Portuguese: *raposa*, from *rabo*, "tail" and Ojibwa: *waagosh*, from *waa*, which refers to the up and down "bounce" or flickering of an animal or its tail. Male foxes are known as dogs or reynards, females as vixen, and young as kits, pups, or cubs. A group of foxes is a "skulk", "troop" or "earth".

In the wild, foxes can live for up to 10 years, but most foxes only live for 2 to 3 years due to hunting, road accidents and diseases. Foxes are generally smaller than other members of the family *Canidae* such as wolves, jackals, and domestic dogs. Reynards (male foxes) weigh on average, 5.9 kilograms (13 lb) and vixens (female foxes) weigh less, at around 5.2 kilograms (11.5 lb). Fox-like features typically include a distinctive muzzle (a "fox face") and bushy tail.